EU tourism strategy seeks to share the gains — and ease the strains

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By Martina Sapio, Tommaso Lecca · Nov 4, 2026, 9:45 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The European Commission’s new tourism strategy aims to defang rising anti-visitor sentiment by trying to spread the benefits across regions and seasons.

The Commission’s first comprehensive tourism strategy , released Wednesday, never uses the word “overtourism,” a term often used to describe tourism pressures in highly popular hotspots — but it’s filled with ideas on how to lessen the negative impacts of a sector that generates 10% of the EU’s GDP and provides more than 20 million jobs.

The Commission’s own research has warned that concentrated tourism can bring surging crowds, traffic, pollution, and fierce competition for housing and land, while straining resources such as fresh water and undermining residents’ quality of life.

Rather than impose rules or cut down the number of tourists, the strategy calls for voluntary measures.

“The Commission’s approach is not to introduce visitor caps or restrictions to popular destinations,” Transport and Tourism Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas told reporters. Any such measures, he said, are “the responsibility of the destination or of the member states.”

“Tourism supports jobs and local economies, but its success also depends on destinations staying livable,” the Greek commissioner said, underlining that locals must have affordable housing and workers need to live close to their jobs.

The tension between economic benefits for tourists and local quality of life has triggered frustration across Europe — the world’s most popular tourist destination.

In July, tens of thousands of people filled the streets of Palma in Spain, protesting mass tourism, gentrification and the strain on public services. Similar protests have swept Barcelona, Venice, and Lisbon.

The answer, said Eduardo Santander, CEO of the European Travel Commission, an industry lobby, is to spread out demand.

“The so-called phenomenon of overtourism … we actually call it unbalanced tourism because what happens is that we tend to go to the same place at the same time,” he said.

But Chiara Capretti, a member of Italy's far-left Power to the People party, said simply steering tourists toward new destinations is a "sham" that will not solve the problem. "You need regulation and public control."

Any regulations will have to come mostly from local and national governments, as the EU has limited sway over tourism. The strategy repeatedly stresses that tourism policy remains largely a national responsibility.

The housing trap

The issue is becoming politically charged and is spilling into areas where Brussels has more say. Wednesday's strategy and September's Affordable Housing Act are "complementary," said Raffaele Fitto, the cohesion commissioner.

"The two initiatives share the same objective: making tourism more sustainable, more balanced, and more beneficial for the people who live and work in our communities," he said.

However, the housing act is seeing national resistance.

Italy's Senate EU affairs committee argued in late October there was no convincing need for EU action.

Finland's government also pushed back against the act and called for changes, warning that the proposal could chip away at national sovereignty. Germany, Lithuania, and Sweden have also raised doubts or launched scrutiny processes over the act.

Some lawmakers in Brussels back the Commission's approach.

Nikolina Brnjac, a Croatian member of the European Parliament with the center-right European People's Party, backed the strategy's proposed management model and call to spread tourism more evenly.

She added that the key is for the strategy to improve people's quality of life — one of the drivers of mass protests.

Maltese S&D MEP Daniel Attard said: "The strategy is a good start, but real investment is needed. If tourism is a strategic sector for Europe, this should be shown in the EU budget."

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